GOOF-UPS AND COUNTER-ATTACKS

The mistakes Mamata made in handling the Aug. 9 rape and murder of a junior doctor, and how she is trying to amend these



GLARING ERRORS

- Refuses to accept the resignation of Sandip Ghosh, principal of RG Kar Hospital, and transfers him instead as principal of the Calcutta National Medical College and Hospital
- Blames Aug. 14 mob vandalism at RG Kar on "Ram and Bam"—the BJP and Left. But the violence is suspected to have been TMC-driven—the cops had watched on silently
- Offers Rs 10 lakh compensation to victim's parents the same day. They refuse to accept it, saying they just want justice
- Asks protesting doctors on Aug. 28 to resume work in a way seen as a threat; police issue notices to 280 protesters, including TMC MP Sukhendu Sekhar Roy
- Urges people on Sept. 9 to prepare for coming festive season, angering many

COURSE CORRECTION

- Passing of Aparajita Woman and Child Bill, proposing time-bound justice, including death penalty, in rape cases
- State government focusing on security overhaul in govt hospitals—6,178 more CCTV cameras, 893 additional duty rooms for doctors
- Action being initiated against doctors accused of malpractices in RGKMCH and elsewhere

bill "a historic step", the TMC hopes to win public support for this initiative. However, many have criticised the bill as a mere diversionary tactic. Secondly, the TMC is trying to highlight the plight of the common people, saying their access to medical services has been affected by the cease-work of junior doctors. During a Supreme Court hearing on the RG Kar incident on September 9, the state submitted a report, alleging that 23 people have died due to this. The health department claims 70,000 patients were not admitted to government hospitals ever since doctors struck work 28 days back. The protesting doctors have refuted the allegations. Finally, the state government is focusing on a security overhaul in state-run hospitals. It told the SC that 6,178 more CCTV cameras will be installed and that 893 additional duty rooms are being set up. Action is also being initiated against the doctors who have been accused of malpractices at RGKMCH and other medical colleges.

To counter the mounting public backlash, Mamata has nephew and TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee by her side. The two met on August 30 to bridge the differences between them ever since Mamata threw her weight behind former principal Ghosh. Abhishek had made his dissent known and was reportedly infuriated when a frenzied mob, allegedly including TMC supporters, ransacked the hospital on the night of August 14.

The CBI arrested Ghosh on charges of graft on September 2; the next day, the state health department suspended him. On September 5, the department also suspended Avik De, a trainee at the Institute of Post-Graduate Medical Education and Research, while the Directorate of Medical Education placed senior resident doctor Birupaksha Biswas under suspension. Both of them, among others, were allegedly associates of Ghosh and part of his corruption racket. These censorious moves bear Abhishek's signature, sources point out. On September 2, to further placate the roused masses, Abhishek rebuked TMC leaders for speaking "ill of anyone from the medical fraternity or civil society". The move came after at least four party leaders had mocked and threatened the protesting doctors.

DIP IN POPULARITY

Such palliative gestures may have come too late to undo the damage. An internal survey by the TMC has shown that public perception of a cover-up and police mismanagement of the probe has pulled down the CM's popularity and her party's credibility to lows that have not been seen since the phase leading up to the 2019 Lok Sabha election, reflecting a wave of anger against the alleged corruption and high-handedness by TMC leaders resulted in the party winning just 22 of Bengal's 42 seats. Yet another survey

Tough action against Sandip Ghosh and his associates bears the mark of Abhishek Banerjee, who opposed some of Mamata's earlier moves